

life, demands that an extra battery pack be carried alongside.

For wireless data transfer, the Fujitsu S2020 with a transfer rate of 2.37 MBps one-upped the Acer 381TCi at 2.03 MBps. This will let you stream music from colleagues without a hitch.

Conclusion

The ACI Ethos Lite and the Acer TravelMate 381TCi, both of which featured an external combo drive, earned almost equal points in the final scorecard, with just a point separating them, and were the second and third runners-up respectively. At the end of the day, the Fujitsu LifeBook S2020 was adjudged the

The mixed marriage between the PDA and the cell phone is promising the ideal breed

PDA-PHONES

We have talked about and tested laptops to this point; that device class in its current avatar is not ideally suited for instant, one-minute tasks. Making a quick phone call, perhaps even a conference call, sending an emergency SMS across, scheduling or rescheduling meetings, taking small notes, recording voice memos, exchanging electronic contact information—such tasks as these require a different beast to drive them.

While a PDA was ideally suited for all these tasks a few years ago, the mixed marriage between that strain of product and the cell phone is promising the ideal breed. What we have termed the PDA-phone is a device that straddles the boundaries, offering the best of both worlds. The key is the means of data entry, then screen size, and then the other features. So why not smartphones? Smartphones typically have much smaller keypads—this is essentially what differentiates them from the PDA-phones we are discussing here, which have a full-fledged data entry system.

In the scenario we've painted, laptops are your primary device, while a device that provides the functionality of a PDA and the connectivity of a cell phone plays the sidekick. Thus, Nokia's Communicator 9500 is more of a phone with slapped-on PDA features, whereas O2's XDA-II mini is essentially a PDA with cell phone features.

We received two devices from Nokia—the 9500 Communicator

and the 7710; the Treo 600 from PalmOne; the O2 XDA II mini; the Blackberry 7730 from Airtel; and the A768i from Motorola. Sony-Ericsson failed to send us the P910i in time.

We tested each of these devices on the various parameters that would be of importance to a mobile professional.

Portability

These devices need to be pocketable. Dimensions, though important, should not affect important elements such as screen size too much; an ideal device will therefore have the correct balance of dimensions and screen size.

Motorola's A768i is most pocketable; the clamshell design aids it further, serving as a screen protector, and you can safely throw it along with loose change and house keys. However, as you will soon find out, the A768i isn't very feature-rich.

The O2 XDA II mini on the other hand, has a perfect balance of dimensions and screen size. Despite its large screen, the O2 mini maintains a small profile, thanks to minimal face buttons, and can be easily slipped into your pocket.

The Blackberry 7730 has a sufficiently large screen, but is somewhat too large to be easily carried—this one is definitely a coat pocket or a trouser pocket device.

The PalmOne Treo 600 is surprisingly small and pocketable; it does have an external antenna, though.

While Nokia's 7710 might be



Fujitsu LifeBook S2020

winner, followed by the Zenith Presidio VU.

Even though the Fujitsu cost Rs 10,000 more than the Zenith, what it lost in price, it made up in features. With a 13.3-inch screen driven by an ATi IGP 320M chipset, the Fujitsu



Zenith Presidio VU

offered a great viewing experience. It also sported a variety of ports, save for a memory card reader—which wasn't present on any of the laptops in this category.

In terms of ergonomics, the Fujitsu excelled. Also worth noting is that it carried along the best software bundle.

How We Tested PDA-Phones

Parameters such as portability, usability and productivity formed the backbone of this PDA comparison.

In 'Portability', we noted the dimensions and the weight of the device. We also looked at whether the device fits easily in a pocket. 'Usability' included general ergonomics, where we assigned scores by typing messages using the QWERTY keyboard/pad or using the stylus.

We also used the device for browsing the Internet, and logged its ability to render Web pages well. As for contact management and schedules, we added some entries and then synchronised the device with a desktop PC to check compatibility with MS Outlook. We also used the provided data backup tool to back up the data, and assigned scores based on how simple this task turned out. We also took the devices' ease of use into account.

In 'Productivity', we assessed how easy to use the bundled software was—such as the word processor, the spreadsheet application, the PDF reader, the presentation tool, the e-mail client, etc.

To obtain realistic values in the battery test, we had the device simulate optimal usage, and noted the time it took for the device to drain the battery from a full charge.